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James Chirillo

Guitarist James Chirillo was born in Waltham, Massachusetts on May 2, 1953. He studied composition at North Texas State and was a member of the U.S. Military Academy Band at West Point. James has performed and recorded with Kenny Davern, Joe Wilder, Benny Goodman and the Smithsonian Jazz Masterworks Orchestra and debuted as a leader on Nagel-Hayer Records.

James was interviewed in New York City on January 12, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are at the IAJE in Manhattan filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton. I'm pleased to have James Chirillo with me tonight. It's fairly late but for jazz musicians it's about the time you'd normally start work.

JC: That's right. Close to it.

MR: Yeah. You think of yourself as a guitarist and a composer.

JC: True.

MR: What's it like trying to get your compositions on a recording or get people to play them?

JC: Good question. You know really I'm not a self-promoter I guess. So in that sense I really can't answer the question. Usually if something of mine has been recorded it's because they asked me to write it for them in the first place. And even that's no guarantee. Even I've written plenty of things that have not been played yet either for that matter. So, but like the clarinet piece I wrote for Ken Peplowski, that actually started from a draft of a melody that I wrote after a hotel gig and I brought it in when I was studying with Johnny Carisi. And I thought I'd ask him about how, here's like a little, just say you dashed something like this off, how would you start to develop this idea. So we talked about various ways. And then maybe about just a few weeks later, if that, he had a stroke which laid him basically semicomatose for about six months and then he passed away. So that material, which originally was a fast tempo kind of theme, just took a whole mournful turn and so I ended up developing it and writing what turned out to be this middle movement of this piece for Ken Peplowski, "Elegy for John Carisi." And that was musically, I was pretty happy with that. That was musically pretty successful as far as I was concerned. And Ken dug it. So I always had had the idea, since that was originally a fast movement theme, why not expand that and I played that for David Baker. And he said, "Man you should apply for a NEA grant and finish writing that thing." So I did and I ended up getting it. So there you go. And Ken had a recording project later on where he was able to bring in a big band, and we used Loren Schoenberg's band and we got it

MR: Boy that's interesting how things can, little pieces of music can hang around for a while and get changed by circumstances that you wouldn't conceive of. And it's worth saving things I guess. And I don't know about you but I find when I write sometimes I plagiarize myself over and over.

JC: Of course. You liked it once, why wouldn't you like it twice?

MR: Yeah. A different arrangement of the same thing.

JC: All the great guys did that.

MR: When you were at North Texas State, I'm going to jump around a little bit, but I've got that on my mind. How much of the — I don't know if you can give me a percentage — but how much of what you learned there turned out to be useful in the real world of a gigging, working musician?

JC: Well in that I was basically about one step removed from a blank slate when I went down there, you know as a self-taught rock & roll guitar player, so I had just started to get into different jazz guitar players when I went down there. Joe Pass and Grant Green, guys like that, of course Wes. But I hadn't even heard of Charlie Parker when I went down there, and I was, when was that, so I was 22.

MR: No kidding.

JC: Yeah. I was into King Crimson and those kind of guys.

MR: Oh, King Crimson.

JC: Yeah, right. Robert Fripp, those guys. I mean of course and Hendrix and all those, Jimmy Page, you name it. So when I went down there, anything that I got exposed to was great. And they had a great classical department too, let alone the jazz department.

MR: What did you get accepted as, and what got you in there? Your compositions?

JC: No. It's not like, I mean back then, and we're talking '75, it was a state university, I mean it still is for that matter. But it wasn't — the whole financial outlay was much less. I remember even then a semester was something between eight and twelve hundred bucks, for a semester's worth of classes. A full load. And roughly the dorm was probably about the same. And after my first year there I ended up getting like a guitar scholarship that Mundell Lowe was paying for, it was like a hundred bucks a semester but if you won a scholarship like that then it enabled you to get in-state rates. So that basically, that hundred dollars took care of the semester's tuition at the in-state rate. So it made my dad happy. But still, I mean that's the thing. So I mean I'm not really sure — I'd gone to — my grades weren't that great in high school because I was young and savage, but when I decided — I took a year off from high school before I got into college and I took two years or so at Bellevue Community College, where I figured I would take all the required kind of things. So I took math and history or this and that. And of course it was — you

know if I decide to use my brain it's going to come out okay, so in high school I wasn't using my brain so much but what the heck.

MR: You were using your King Crimson.

JC: When you're that age — oh Lord, no. I'm not even going to go where I was just thinking. Stupidity knows no bounds. But that's beside the point. Suffice it to say I got, you know, like a 3.9 or whatever the heck it was when I was going to the community college, so I sent those transcripts down and that's probably why they accepted me. You know 'cause musically I was pretty savage.

MR: Well if you were learning some of the bands you mentioned, were you learning them by ear off the records?

JC: Right.

MR: Okay well that's good training.

JC: Oh yeah.

MR: I don't care what kind of music. Because there's some difficult playing in that.

JC: Absolutely, sure. You know and a couple of buddies of mine, you know you're always playing at that age, you're always playing with your friends and this and that. And we'd be turning each other on to different things that we were learning. There was a piano player, a guy named Dave Lewis, who eventually moved out to the West Coast and was in a band called Ambrosia. I guess they were pretty happening there for a while.

MR: They had a big hit.

JC: Yeah he was a great piano player. I haven't heard him in a long time but he was a great piano player. And he turned me on to Béla Bartok, he was learning some "Mikrokosmos" at the time. So it's just, you get exposed to this stuff. My first semester composition class at North Texas, my very first class, the guy, the teacher, God I can picture him perfectly and I can't remember his name now — I want to say George Johnson or something, but I'm not sure. Anyway my very first class he had all these articles on different topics that everybody could pick one and then give a report on the article to the class the following week. And the one that I got was an article written in the *Musical Quarterly* about Elliot Carter's "Piano Sonata." So that was the first time I heard Elliot Carter. So that was great. You know, so just, man, anything and everything.

MR: There was a whole world out there that you weren't aware of.

JC: Absolutely.

MR: And you played in the One O'clock Band. That was pretty well known.

JC: Oh yeah, to answer your question, pardon me, I'm sort of throwing a ball around, running with the ball, I mean there are certain things you're not — nobody is going to learn at a college because you're not in a professional playing situation. I mean if you show up to

something, and the band leader, you know "bring the mutes" aww you don't feel like bringing them, whatever it is. Sometimes in college guys out there don't feel like bringing mutes, schlepping them around all day or whatever, so they don't bring them to class or to the ensemble or whatever, that's reason enough for the guy not to call you back for the job next time, no matter how good you read. So it's those kind of things you're not going to learn at the school. But in terms of all the — we were sight reading music all the time. I mean Leon Breeden was the band director there when I was there. And he didn't actually start that program but he really built it up. And he had pulled things for us to read, and he'd count them off and he'd leave, you know he'd go back in the office. He knew what the thing sounded like, he didn't need to see us read the thing, whatever. Or he'd look at whoever the lead alto player was, "Here, you guys read through these three or four things, I've got to go, I've got stuff I've got to do in the office." And we'd just run them down. So we were constantly playing new music and we're doing all sort of new and different things. All different kind of styles. And so you know you play a Thad Jones chart, you play a Sammy Nestico chart, so then you're doing the Freddie Green thing, and I always had a good feeling for that. Nobody told me how to do that but you start to — you listen to those Basie records for instance, and you know you hear just that feeling that he's putting in there. You may not even hear him that well. When you start, like you start learning the different chords and the voicings and as you're playing with the band you just start to hone it down. You start realizing if you're playing all these notes, four and five note chords, it's just mushing things up. It doesn't feel right, it doesn't help. You get down to maybe three notes, okay that's better, but — and then once in a while you start hitting like the one note or maybe two notes and that's it, you go oh yeah, okay. It feels right now. Now it feels like it's supposed to go.

MR: What a great process of discovery, really, to figure that out. I was zooming around on the internet actually and went looking for you, and I found this response you had written to someone about Freddie Green.

JC: The Freddie Green website, right.

MR: Right. I was like amazed at the detail that, like I forget that there are people that are crazy about absolutely everything. But he's worth being crazy about. But I had never heard — Bucky explained a little bit of the way he thinks about it and it made sense. But you're talking about using a little fingernail.

JC: In this end, right. That's right. Well Bucky will tell you that too if you really start asking him about different things.

MR: Oh it's a right hand thing.

JC: It's a right — yeah, you get a little of that right hand index fingernail.

JC: Part of that brushes across the strings.

MR: With the pick?

JC: With the pick.

MR: Okay.

JC: It's not like you're really — but it's just, I'd be playing and I was playing for years, and you start doing it and you say to yourself okay, now this sounds right, this feels right, especially when we were talking about Mel Lewis a little earlier. And you know playing with him, you know I mean it's pretty easy to get it to feel right. But I'm playing with him and you start hitting that thing, the guitar in a certain way, and you can, okay right, this is how it's supposed to go. And I'd been playing for years doing that kind of rhythm playing and all this, and you know, this fingernail always would get worn down and you know after a while I'd notice one side is totally lopsided and this is all kind of a weird twisted edge to it and all that stuff. I can tell you I was hitting the thing, all right. But I'd never made the connection that that's partly what's making that sound. And a student came over who had studied with Bucky and we're talking about playing this, and he says, "Oh yeah, Bucky says you've got to get a little fingernail in here." I thought oh yeah, of course, that's why I'm always wearing this thing down because that's what I'm doing.

MR: You have to take a certain pride in providing that correctly, that Freddie Green thing. I mean maybe I'm stating the obvious but I don't think all guitar players can be content with doing that.

JC: Yeah, well it's — most don't. It is, it's a very limiting role. If that's all I did I'd get, I'd probably go nuts too. Freddie Green was pretty special. I mean you've giving a hundred percent all the time, I mean never solo. And why do you think Freddie Green never soloed, because his strings were up so damn — pardon me — so high. You know and basically if those strings are up really high and he had really heavy gauge, thick, heavy strings, with the bridge set so that they're very high above the fingerboard so that you get really high tension, so basically the amount of strength it takes just to hold a string down is the equivalent say, I always say, well it's basically you're doing the equivalent of crushing rocks all day.

MR: Wow. He must have had a strong left hand I guess.

JC: I don't think you'd want to shake lefties with him. And so you can't, if you're playing some light bebop line you can not do that on a guitar where basically you're jumping on every note, you've got to jump in the hole with both feet just to get that thing down, see?

MR: Did you ever hear those anecdotes about for a while he had an amp and the guys in the band sabotaged it?

JC: Oh yeah, yeah right.

JC: That's right.

MR: Well were your parents supportive of your — I assume when you went to North Texas State you were thinking well I'm going to a career in music.

JC: Yeah, right.

MR: Were they okay with that?

JC: Yeah. I mean my grandfather initially was a professional trumpet player, my dad's dad. He played the Panamanian Exposition of, what was that, 1908 or something like that. And he met my grandmother and she said, "Look if you want to marry me you're going to have to get a job. A real job. Typical. And so he was in the New York City Sanitation Department a garbage man. But then after a while, but that was back in the days when the City had, every department had their own band. The Fire Department had their own band, the Police Department, all the departments had their bands. The Sanitation Department had their own band. They even had their own conductor, an Italian conductor. And most of the guys in the band were Italian guys. All this is just to say that they had like some serious training and there was like plenty of time where he wasn't even like lifting garbage cans anymore, he was just out there playing different events with that band. The '39 World's Fair in New York, he was playing the World's Fair every day. The Queen Mary would come in and he'd go down and play for whoever was coming in on the Queen Mary. So there was a little respect for that already in the family. My father was a career Navy officer and they bought me my first guitar. My brother had an old Sears & Roebuck acoustic archtop and I just ended up beating on it more than him. And when I was 13 my parents bought me a little Vox electric guitar. So you've got to say they were supportive, but you know, I was making nothing but pretty savage noise on it back in those days. And when I was being particularly — shall we say — difficult, to put it politely, my old man looked and he says, "What are you going to do with yourself? You ain't going to do that." And I said, "I'm planning on doing this with my life." He says basically you've got to be kidding me. I mean because I was just making a lot of noise. But then as he saw I got more and more serious, and of course when I was going to Bellevue Community College and bringing home the grades, and I was taking other music classes there too, then yeah, then I went to North Texas and it was the same thing, I was 3.9 or whatever the heck it was down there too. So yeah, then they knew I was getting serious and I ended up in that One O'clock and you know we toured. We did a State Department tour in 1976 of Russia of the Soviet Union, so we went all over. My first time overseas. A week in Portugal. You know it was great. And I was totally ignorant, I had no idea. But it was highball. And you know, yeah, so I got that scholarship as I had mentioned before. So yeah, they were supportive, absolutely.

MR: Is there some, was there a big break for you when you look back on post-college then, was there a relationship with a particular musician or something that happened that you felt really opened things up?

JC: There's no one guy I can single out, I can name, for different aspects, of being able to stick around and stay alive. As a musician there's plenty of guys I can name. I went to North Texas in spring, January, whatever, the spring semester but it starts in January of 1975. And I didn't try out for a jazz band, they'd already pretty much had all that stuff settled from September or whatever, previous. But in the summer, for the summer bands, and I just stayed down there and went to school in the summer, for the summer bands Leon directed it also, but they only had like a band, one band, and it was just from whoever was around. So whoever wanted to like apply, you could end up playing in this band and whatever. So it's not like you had to really audition for it or nothing. And that first summer I played in that band and that's when a great guitar player teacher, a guy named Jack Peterson, decided to start teaching at college again. He's the guy that actually started the guitar program at Berklee back in, I think the late fifties. He really got that going. And he's an old Texas boy, so he ended moving back down to Dallas and got involved in the whole commercial jingle scene. There was a lot of jingle recording back then in those days, and he was doing everything because he plays great and of course he could arrange like nobody's business. So then he got tired of doing that and he decided to get back into teaching. So that was that first — so he heard me back then. So I learned a lot from him. I learned a lot from him. And playing at North Texas, they had a band in Dallas at the Fairmont Hotel that actually was it first started, — I forget exactly how that band, how they decided on picking Jerry Gray, but the guy, whoever made that decision, he loved Glenn Miller and Jerry Gray particularly. And he got Jerry Gray to be the band leader at the Fairmont Hotel in Dallas back then, in the early seventies. So he had a great band. Now I think he had just like stopped leading that band right about when I got down there and maybe even had passed away at that time, I'm not really quite sure when Jerry Gray passed away. So I never met him personally. But he's the guy that got that band going which was a great band. So they'd bring acts in and they didn't have a steady guitar player, so when they had a show come in, an act come in, that they needed a guitar player, they'd usually try the North Texas guys or whatever, because they could read okay. So I started doing some of those. Joey Heatherton came down and she brought with her her musical director/drummer, a guy named Jerry Fisher, crazy Jerry Fisher — a good guy though, a good drummer — and Jerry Bruno was the bass player. She brought him down. And so Jerry Bruno and I were sitting next to each other for a couple of weeks doing the show and we just sort of hit it off, you know, I mean he played with Frank

had a great time. He said, "Man, if you ever come to New York give me a call." So I ended up saving my money, I ended up joining the Army, in the band, I was in the band at West Point for three years, saved money, moved to New York in 1982, I called up Jerry Bruno and he said come down to the union on Wednesday, you'll meet whatever, and I'll introduce you to everybody I know. He introduced me to everybody he knew and a year later just about to the day I realized I had fifty dollars left in the bank. And no money, and a guy that Jerry Bruno had introduced me to called me and offered me a three day a week job at the Grand Hyatt Hotel. And I was there for five years.

MR: Wow. Talk about timing.

JC: Timing, oh yeah. Yeah that's what you get if you don't look at the checkbook. I knew I was getting close. So anyway it's not like I ever had like loads of money but I never really worried about it either.

MR: Well your wife is also a musician.

JC: Right.

MR: So you guys are, you're a pair of musicians, which can be —

JC: It can be. But you know it's really, if you just like keep doing it long enough then eventually you know enough people and enough things just always, you always end up getting enough to make ends meet. I've never really worried about it, ever.

MR: What was it like studying with Tiny Grimes?

JC: Ah, well there's another one. Now I really got a concept of sound from him too. Tiny, I mean he was very down to earth, very straight ahead. And of course he was only maybe around for a few more years after from I first met him and started studying with him. But like Tiny now, a couple of quick anecdotes about Tiny, when I first met him I just saw like a poster in the neighborhood, I was living Uptown, about him playing at the Jazz Cultural Center, which was a place — they presented concerts — but also it was used in an educational sense by Barry Harris. He started that baby up. So I saw this, okay Tiny Grimes at the boom — so I went down there and then I got down there a little bit early or whatever, and he's just — Tiny's just sitting in a chair warming up on that four string guitar and I just walked over the introduced myself and we started talking, and I'd picked up a couple of his records, "Some Groovy Fours." Anyway, so a guitar player, he figures okay, he hands me his guitar and he says, "Here, play me something." So okay. So I figured a four string guitar, that kind of chordal style maybe, I thought well Jack Peterson had taught me Dick McDonough's guitar solo from 1934 on "Honeysuckle Rose," a great little acoustic, rhythm-based chordal style of that tune. Dick McDonough was great if you never heard of him before. So I played that. So Tiny sort of dug that.

MR: You passed his audition, yeah.

JC: Yeah. You know, and the lesson, I forget how much he charged me but it wasn't much, but part of the lesson was, I mean, when I show up you've got to have a *New York Post* and either one or two quarts of Ballantyne Ale, depending on how he was feeling that day. That was Tiny. But he told me he never practiced so much, ever in his life, as when he was playing with the Art Tatum Trio.

MR: I can imagine.

JC: You know he said he'd only been playing the guitar for three years when he ended up in that trio. Slam had perfect pitch so if Art just sort went that-a-way he'd go, but neither of those guys would be telling him nothing. But there was one good one where — Bill Finegan told me this one — that trio was playing somewhere, at some joint. Art Tatum's doing "Lover" and of course he's totally tearing it up and it's [claps], tearing it up for chorus after chorus. Totally tearing it up. So he's rolling around on this last chorus and he sort of, up at Tiny, "Okay you got it." Tiny yells back, "I don't want it." That's Tiny Grimes.

MR: Well that's hard to — I used to play with a guitar player like that who played so much, so much for so many choruses, then he says, "You got it." So I said you already said all of it. I have nothing to add.

JC: I know. You've got to save some for the next guy, that's true.

MR: Bill Finegan, God, he's got an interesting reputation from all his work. Further composition studies with him?

JC: Oh yeah. Orchestration and arranging. He studied with Stephan Wolpe too. And he said Wolpe, you know a German, an emigre German basically serialist composer, extremely intense. His music is sort of like — it makes Arnold Schoenberg look like "Tea for Two" in a sense. It's pretty — it's really intense stuff. But very organized. But as I mentioned, Carisi studied with this guy and Eddie Sauter studied with him too. But Bill said, he had a little like downstairs room. I don't know if that was just an apartment or just a room, but you know you've got to go down like some stairs to get to where his room was, like a little basement kind of thing. And just to make a point, like Bill said he'd bring something in and maybe he had on the second eight just repeat something or whatever, the second eight phrase he repeated the same thing he did the first time. And he said Wolpe would say, "Why do you want to do it the same way? We just heard it that way once already." And then he said he'd jump up from the piano and he would like run around and go up like the stairs a few steps and then go say his name — Stephan Wolpe's, so American he'd say Steve, he'd say, "It's like you saying 'hi Steve' and walk around and go around to the other side of the piano and go 'hi Steve.'" You're still just saying 'hi Steve." A good way to get the point across.

JC: Yeah, Finegan. I mean have you heard that Warren Vache string ensemble?

MR: I haven't heard that yet.

JC: Bill wrote three arrangements on that. And when you listen to those, aside from the fact that they sound just gorgeous and they just set those tunes up perfectly for Warren and they just sound great, just think that he wrote those sitting on the sofa. Because he's hurting, his back, he's been having some back problems or whatever. The point is it hurt his back to sit at the piano, so he wrote those sitting on the sofa.

MR: Can you do that?

JC: No. Not like that.

MR: No, me neither.

JC: If I had learned right probably when I was young I could have developed that capacity. But I didn't really learn — I learned a lot more playing-wise and getting a sound — I mean I can hear really good, don't — my relative pitch is about as good as you're going to ever need it to get. Yeah, but I can't do a void — not write something like that. I mean if I look at a score I've got to really think to start to hear different lines and make sure I'm really hearing the harmony, I've got to really concentrate on that.

MR: Does your — do you think being a composer and having studied composing affects the way you improvise?

JC: Of course. Yeah. Most really great composers could play something, and usually pretty darn good. Beethoven you know, when he played his first piano concerto, I forget for what prince he was writing it for but whatever, but he showed up and the piano was tuned, the piano concerto was written in C, but the piano was tuned and it had settled like a half step low. So he played his part in D flat that day.

MR: That's pretty scary.

JC: So I guess the point is yeah, when you're writing something the challenge is, especially if it's like how most jazz players — let me back up a bit. If you're playing a standard tune, a tune that the audience already knows, that your listening audience already is familiar with, be it by Irvin Berlin or who knows, but they already know the melody. Now you're going to do it in a way that, the challenge is, hopefully, that it's going to sound fresh to them. So and that doesn't mean like totally rewrite the tune. Maybe you want to throw in a little different harmony or something, okay. But then even when you're playing, if you've got that same old tune and you're with a group or whatever, maybe you have one horn or maybe it's just guitar trio or whatever. How many choruses of that are you going play where it's going to be exactly the same? You're not going to change key on every chorus. You're not going to totally rewrite the harmony on every chorus. I mean chances are unless you have the luxury of a working trio, like the same guys you're really used to

know the tune, you're going to play the tune. That's it. It's not like you're going to rehearse it or anything. So how do you make those same notes sound fresh? And it's the same thing with writing a great arrangement or if you write a piece, you write a tune, whatever it is, your ideas, how do you make them sound fresh but still logically a coherent part of the whole. And so yeah, of course, studying Brahms, oh man Brahms, Gabrieli, all those guys, Palestrina. Now this is something that Finegan told me now dig this. Eddie Sauter wrote for Benny Goodman. Benny Goodman hired Bartok, he commissioned, they played that "Contrasts." He wrote that "Contrasts" for Joseph Szigeti himself to play on the piano and Benny Goodman on the clarinet, right? And Bartok came, and Szigeti, maybe he was already here, whatever. He came to New York and they recorded that at RCA in nineteen thirty whatever it was. Maybe it was early forties, I forget. But okay, so Eddie Sauter, I mean he knew Benny. I mean he made it a point of I'm going to get down to RCA that day, and so Bill Finegan told me this, at a quiet moment in the action Eddie Sauter went up to Béla Bartok and introduced himself and you know, "Maestro Bartok, I'm a writer myself" and on and what you've done. "What advice do you have for the young writer?" And he said the only thing Bartok would tell him was, "Study Palestrina." Now dig that. And then now you get into Bartok a little more, as far as you start really checking into some of the things he's done besides just like the really main pieces like "Concerto for Orchestra" or something like that, and you find that he's written 27 two or three part vocal — pieces for vocal chorus, for either childrens' or womens' chorus, 27 small pieces. And these are a direct result of him studying a book on sixteenth century counterpoint in the style — by a Danish musicologist named Jeppesen, and Bartok read it, on dissonance in the style of Palestrina. Kodaly said he was always bugging Bartok, "Why don't you write some vocal music already? Come on, we need some vocal." He ended up reading that book and getting into Palestrina's style like that and he wrote those 27 pieces. And to hear how he works and overlaps those motifs and everything, with some of those Hungarian scales and those Hungarian modes and his sense of rhythm and everything. It's — oh man those things are beautiful. If you ever get a chance to hear those check those out.

MR: Tell me about Benny Goodman. How did that come about?

JC: Well Loren Schoenberg was working for Benny at that time. He was sort of like his secretary, and, you know, fielding phone calls, doing things, whatever. But Loren had had his own — pardon me — he had his own band, and when, from what I gather, when Benny was approached by PBS to do a PBS special, "Let's Dance," he just asked Loren to put the band together, to get a band together. And Loren always had an interest, I mean his primary interest, especially at that time, whenever he would get his band together,

Benny had heard that band and says, "Get that band together." I was pretty new in town, Loren knew me though. And I gather for the first rehearsal Howard Alden did the first rehearsal, and he was playing in that band at that time, but he couldn't make the next one. And so Loren called me and I did it, and I don't know if — for whatever reason — either Benny said let him go or Loren said you know I want to use this guy, but who knows, but I ended up doing it. So there you go. Yeah Benny. I mean everybody hears those stories about him. I mean he could be a real gentleman and then he could be diabolically nasty to musicians. Like I was telling you, we would rehearse at the Wellington Hotel. I mean sometimes he'd take the whole band out for like a great lunch, dinner, whatever, spring for the whole thing. You know, at a top dollar, Upper East Side joint. And at one of those rehearsals at the Wellington, Jack Lesberg was playing bass — first time I ever got a chance to play with Jack. He played the first hour or whatever it was of the rehearsal. Benny, on the breaks says, "What do you think of the bass player?" I said, "Boy, man, he's got a great beat, he plays right in tune, man I'm having a ball." I remember that. It's almost verbatim exactly what I said. Benny says, "Oh okay." He goes right from me, walks over to Jack Lesberg, puts his hand on his shoulder and says, "Jack, I don't think it's going to work out," and sends him home. That's when Murray Wahl started playing with the band. He got Murray Wahl.

MR: Gee. Jack Lesberg?

JC: Jack Lesberg. He fired me after a while, so what the heck.

MR: He fired you too?

JC: Oh yeah. Good company.

MR: Well yeah. You're not the only one, right? But do you know what you did to make him do that?

JC: Who knows. Probably, if he feels you've got any kind of musical weakness at all then it's like, he just sort of goes for the jugular I guess. He got me when I wasn't maybe as secure or settled, I was a lot younger, so—

MR: Wow. Well it was nice you had that experience anyway.

JC: Oh yeah. I mean whenever we would play, I mean he was what 78 or something, you know he, by himself, could take that band up to another level easy. When he felt like playing he could just ratchet it up.

MR: Well I have a little drop the needle test for you. This is going to be easy, trust me. I wouldn't —

[audio interlude]

MR: See now that's funny because, I forget who was here earlier today and I played something and it was them and they didn't recognize themselves.

MR: I like that. So a high school student says, "So what do you think about when you improvise?" Can you answer that?

JC: Well I'm thinking about that melody and I'm hearing the harmony at the same time.

MR: You're thinking about the original melody.

JC: Absolutely. Yeah. Otherwise why bother playing that tune? Why — you might as well improvise — otherwise, if all you're thinking about is like maybe the chords or something like that, then all you're going to do is the same patterns on "Cheek to Cheek" that you would on "Lotus Blossom." So the whole thing, for me, is — and again it's on a composition — compositionally speaking too — if you're going to improvise on a tune, your primary focus should be you're coming up with variations of that melody. That's the idea.

MR: That's the idea.

JC: That's what I always thought.

MR: Well me too.

JC: So yeah. So that's what I'm thinking about when I'm improvising. I'm just playing that — all I'm doing is playing the tune.

MR: Okay so does that concept work if you're playing — oh gosh — like "So What?" Or if you're playing a song that's modal and it's got two chord changes, and the first, I mean, you know what I'm saying?

JC: Yeah. Well I haven't probably played that tune since I was at North Texas State.

MR: Really?

JC: Oh sure. And only because — not that it can't be a valid musical experience — but I don't know, for me my ear gets fatigued with the same tonality after a while. And if it's that same minor mode, even though it goes up a half step, okay, okay I heard that trick once already. Go down a half step maybe, but no, they still always go up. Okay. Whatever. I'm just trying to make a point. So I just don't find it as interesting to play. Back then I didn't really, I couldn't really even differentiate between different kind of minor modes. So that Dorian mode kind of sound, that was one I could relate to with my rock kind of experience, it was the minor mode but you still had the dominant seventh and all that kind of stuff and it worked really good. So I could hear it. So that made it good for me back then. But even now, if I played that tune now I'd still try to work off that idea.

MR: Or the bass line.

JC: Right. That's what it is. Yeah.

MR: That's really the melody.

JC: That's what it is, that's the melody, right, sure. Absolutely. That's I mean, for me that kind of a tune is a lot harder to play than "Cheek to Cheek" and really make it interesting. Yeah.

MR: There's less —

JC: Less to work with.

MR: Yeah, less to work with. It's — I don't know — it's interesting that jazz went that way somehow. Maybe the musicians were reacting to the intensity of like "Giant Steps" and those like — all those chords coming so fast. They says well that's about as far as we can go with that.

JC: Yeah right. You know that was really an exercise you know, "Giant Steps" was. That's a hard tune too. But yeah, I mean that's just an exercise. And even that, in and of itself because it just keeps on going around like that, that gets old to me too after a while. I would rather listen to "Cheek to Cheek" because that to me has a sense of logic, you know, that states a premise, it develops it and puts the capper on it. You know to me I find that a more interesting journey. "Giant Steps," I mean somebody that knows what they're doing with that I mean it's impressive, you can't argue the point. But it just keeps on sort of going. For that same reason is why I don't always dig — some of Wagner's great — but some of his other stuff it's the same thing. It never seems to like really get to the point, it just keeps on sort of going. Ut — no it doesn't really resolve here, no we're doing this again but now we're in another place to do it, and it just sort of continually goes and never really finally goes ta-da — you know it never really gets there. So "Giant Steps" sort of strikes me the same way.

MR: Yeah. You make your living playing usually small combo gigs and solo things?

JC: A lot of different things.

MR: A lot of different things. Like you'll play a wedding if you get a call to play a wedding?

JC: Oh yeah, sure.

MR: You'll play like a Kenny Davern type gig on a jazz concert.

JC: Yeah, yup.

MR: And anything that comes along.

JC: Banjo, a lot of banjo, absolutely.

MR: Oh that's right.

JC: Absolutely. A lot of traditional. Because especially banjo, it's playing rhythm, it's playing time down and laying time down. And a good rhythm player, and that could be a bass player or whatever, you should be able to hold the fort whether anybody else is playing or not. So I do a lot of jobs where there is not a drummer. Duo gigs, even when there's no bass player, because I can hold the fort. I don't need to have a drummer doing

— you just go along for the ride, that just is so easy when it's like that. But you get the idea. So yeah, I mean a lot of different things. Sometimes traditional Dixie kind of things like for school programs for elementary school kids during the day, concerts with Jazz at Lincoln Center, we did the "Rhapsody in Blue" with Marcus Roberts and then we started out with Ferde Grofe's original orchestration which is banjo, but then he opens it up in the middle and changes it around so you're reading the original banjo part. And then, on that concert, we did that, we did some Gershwin tunes that were arranged by Nelson Riddle for Ella and Frank Sinatra so then I'm playing acoustic rhythm guitar and that was great, oh man that was great to be in the middle of that. You know they had the American Composers Orchestra so we had the full complement of strings and extra winds and everything. And then we also did a modern piece by a guy named Derek Bermel which was like electric guitar with distortion stuff and you name it, so I went — read, I mean odd measured numbers, bars and times and whatever. So —

MR: Like King Crimson, right?

JC: All in the same concert from nineteen twenty whatever it was on the banjo to this stuff, yeah. So there aren't many guys that can do that so that was good, good for me.

MR: We were having a discussion with a few people today about traditional jazz and they feel it's not well represented in the jazz education scene. And I'm trying to figure out why. Why is the music of Charlie Parker and John Coltrane given more artistic weight than, you know the music of Jean Goldkette or —

JC: Yeah or Bix or —

MR: Or Bix or that kind of thing.

JC: Or Duke for that matter.

MR: Yeah.

JC: Of course Duke, his image has been changing quite a bit I'd say over the last twenty years or so, wouldn't you?

MR: Yeah.

JC: Even in the jazz education thing. Hmm. Well now we enter the realm of conjecture. How do I know? Am I copping a plea? I don't know. I mean, like I say, I can conjecture. I mean I think the bottom line is simply somebody is going to teach what they feel most comfortable with and what they most like. So the generation of educators that are out there in the jazz college scene or jazz high school, whatever, those are the guys, they really, I mean maybe they listen to Duke, maybe they listen to Bix and the older guys or whatever, Louis. I mean Louis Armstrong, as far as I'm concerned, if it doesn't come out of Louis Armstrong, it doesn't swing, you know what I mean? I mean for me that's what that is. And jazz now encompasses so many more influences than just a straight swing

a lot of other things. So whatever is going to get taught is going to get taught, it's going to reflect the guys who are teaching it. And if that's what they're into, that's what's going to be the focus.

MR: Sometimes I just think, when I listen to it, it's so happy, most of it, it's so joyous.

JC: Oh the traditional stuff.

MR: The traditional stuff.

JC: Yeah, it is, it's happy music.

MR: And sometimes I think maybe that works against it as far as being considered weighty and artistic and worth dissecting.

JC: That's very true.

MR: Because Lord knows they've dissected, you know, almost every other kind of jazz.

JC: That's right, I know. It's almost as if it's an accepted corollary that if it's happy stuff then it can't be that serious. It's not serious. And again, as far as I'm concerned if Louis Armstrong did it that's serious enough for me. If Duke Ellington did it, that's serious enough for me. If Red Allen did it, that's serious — Jack Teagarden, and the list just goes on and on and on. And those guys, those were the guys that defined everything that we're doing today. Those were the guys who John Coltrane and Cannonball and Johnny Hodges, who was Cannonball listening to? Willie Smith, Benny Carter, Johnny Hodges, who was he listening to?

MR: I thought of that yesterday when I had this recording of him doing "Stars Fell on Alabama" [scats] just like Johnny Hodges.

JC: Well you know where he got that from, right, of course. That's right, all those guys. Yeah, so I mean I've been really lucky. I got to New York right when some of those guys were still around, so I got to play with Eddie Durham, Eddie Barefield.

MR: Really?

JC: Barefield. I mean he got an idea, I mean I heard Zoot Sims, Zoot Sims came down and did "Spoleto." When they had a Spoleto Festival in Charleston, South Carolina in the late seventies for a couple of years and they brought the North Texas band out there. So we'd back up whoever they would bring in. And they never would bring in guitar players. So the whole North Texas rhythm section had to take a break, but I got to play with, I mean we did a couple of nights with Ella so I got to play with Tommy Flanagan and Keter Betts, Keter, who I played with plenty over the last few years until he just passed away like a year ago. All these guys. So they had this Spoleto — what was I starting to talk about? You were talking about —

MR: Zoot Sims?

JC: Zoot, yeah. Zoot came and did a concert with us. Now I'd sort of heard the name but you

this guy had done. I mean I heard him in the Woody Herman band recordings or something like that but I was basically totally ignorant. But all I knew was — and you know he was such a like a slight, quiet character, I mean physically slight. He wasn't like a big strapping guy. But he seemed very low key, very quiet. It's not like I really talked to him or hung out or got to know him or anything. But when he started to play that saxophone, then it really struck me. That's how a saxophone's supposed to sound. That's — and again, he didn't need any rhythm section playing to show him where the time was. I said that's how it's supposed to go. That's what it's supposed to sound like. So you hear a few guys like that and I mean that's it.

MR: I got to play a few gigs with Claude "Fiddler" Williams. You did quite a bit with him.

JC: Yeah I worked with Claude.

MR: That was fun.

JC: Yeah, now Claude was another one. He said he used to play with Charlie Parker when he was still learning how to play the saxophone in Kansas City.

MR: That's so wild to think of that.

JC: Claude, now again, he was a real little guy, very quiet, and you know, since he was so old, I think when he died he was 94 or something like that. Right? Something like that. So people are always, he was very quiet. And it's almost like, it's just sort of like how he was. He almost wouldn't like register if somebody was talking to him that he didn't really know. He'd be taking it all in but he wouldn't be registering anything. So a lot of people didn't really know exactly maybe how on top of it maybe mentally he was, but believe me he was all there. And there would always be some violin players that would show up and they'd always ask to sit in, and, "Oh, okay. Okay, yeah we'll play a couple numbers." And he'd take it easy on the first couple of numbers. But then I'll bring you up there. So then he'd take it easy on the first couple of numbers. And he's pick some tune like I remember this one person got up there and he said, "How about 'Over the Rainbow,'" which is a little tricky tune, it's got some funny spots to it. I mean if you don't know, really know that tune, I mean that can throw you a couple of curve balls. So the person goes, "Okay, yeah." I mean everybody knows "Over the Rainbow." So he'd let him take the first chorus — let's say it was a she in this case — let her take the first chorus and she'd go okay but you could tell she didn't really know the ins and outs of that, and then of course he'd just tore it up. You know and then the next tune maybe he'd do something like with a bit of a tempo and then he'd just — he would assume stance, I don't know if you — you played with him right?

MR: Yeah, he did.

JC: He'd get in that stance where he'd just be rocking on both — he'd be standing up but he's

these guys. Any time anybody got up there to sit in I never saw him fail to totally annihilate these guys. But he was always very low key and next thing they knew they were like — it was so funny.

MR: He called — we were playing and it was an A-A-B-A song. At some point he said "channel."

JC: "Channel," yeah.

MR: That's the first time I'd heard that. I loved that. It's like oh yeah, okay. That makes sense.

JC: That's an old school term.

MR: To think you're playing with a guy who was Basie's first guitar player.

JC: Before Freddie Green.

MR: Before Freddie Green. Gee. What's the outlook for your working scene? Do you think it will change in the near future? Have you pretty much established yourself?

JC: Well I mean I'm as established as anybody's going to get. I'm not primarily known as a soloist. It always seems like I'm a behind the scenes guy, helping make somebody else look good. Nothing wrong with that. Like I said, I'm not a self-promoter, so that's got something to do with it too. But in terms of you know, a lot of the — say those jazz parties, those are all, mostly all sponsored and attended by, you know the generation ahead of you and me. And so yeah, I don't see how that whole work scene can not change because they're not really getting replaced by anybody. So probably, I don't know exactly what direction, you know, my career personally is going to take. Maybe I'll start pushing — have to start self-promoting more, start doing more things on my own as a leader, which is, I mean that's probably way overdue. But yeah, there will probably be fewer jazz parties per se, there will probably be, probably more of an emphasis — I started doing some education things for Jazz at Lincoln Center. Last summer I did their band director's academy. And I did the Essentially Ellington which required giving like classes and workshops and things. So, and I'm pretty good at that too. So you know, chances are, maybe not necessarily only like through them or whatever, but I'll probably do some more things on the educational level. I can't see myself being a college teacher per se. But that's just 'cause I can't see it.

MR: So you get any studio work? I mean like commercial?

JC: Sure — no, commercial, no, naah. I did a couple of Woody Allen film soundtracks with Dick Hyman, he was the M.D. And on one, I mean he needed acoustic rhythm and banjo, I mean he had like a full studio orchestra, that kind of rhythm playing. So I'm good at that. So I did that. And I subbed for Bucky playing rhythm on one track of that "Sweet and Lowdown." But it's not like — most of the jingles you hear or commercial music, it's all rock oriented stuff, most of it. And I never got into that in the first place, even

when it wasn't rock so no reason for them to call me now, that's for sure. No, I mean I'll probably do other like recordings for smaller jazz labels and those kinds of things.

MR: I enjoyed your release on Nagel-Hayer.

JC: Thank you.

MR: Nice — two tunes on there of yours that I liked.

JC: Thanks.

MR: Do you have trouble finding titles for your work?

JC: Well the solution to that is just don't write many things. You don't have to come up with that many titles. Sorry. I mean 'cause not really.

MR: Okay.

JC: But I mean partly it probably is because I don't write that much. I mean when I write I'm slow, whatever. But when it comes out it's good, whatever comes out is good. But I mean Duke Ellington and Billy Strayhorn, those guys were cranking it out. They came up with all —it's amazing, I mean it still is amazing, the titles they would come up with.

MR: Well I enjoyed our conversation.

JC: Thanks.

MR: I enjoyed dinner, thanks for taking us to that Ralph's, that was nice.

JC: Ah. I just turned you on to Ralph's, you're the one that took me, thank you.

MR: Okay. Well I hope to see you in the near future and the best of luck.

JC: All right. Thanks Monk. All right.